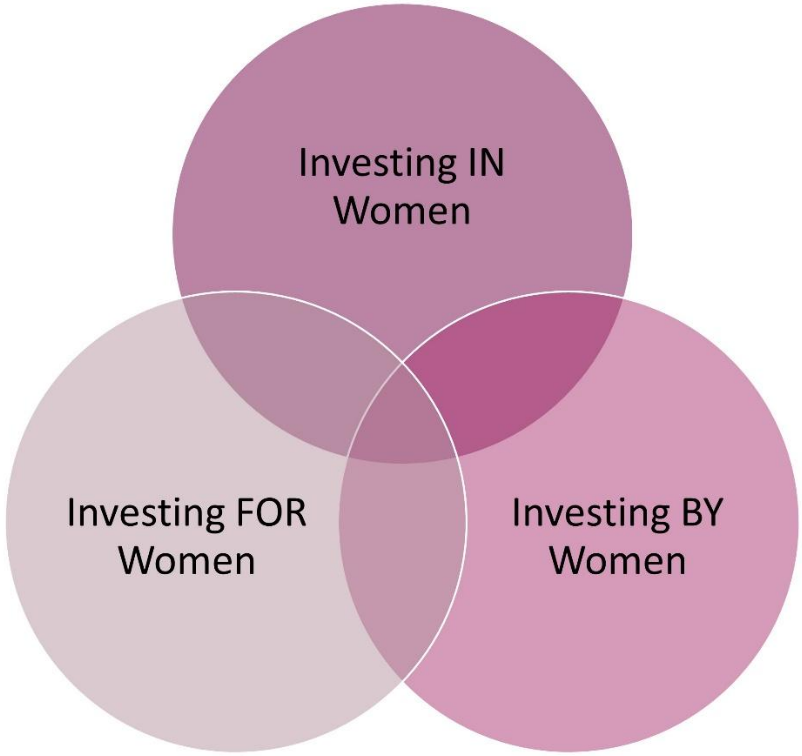

Gender Lens Investing 2025

Review of Sustainable and Equality-focused Investing

April 2025

17th Edition

Parallelle
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Contents

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Executive Summary

We present our 17th quarterly review of gender lens and sustainable investing, marking our fifth year-end summary of data and developments in (a) women in the global economy and workplace and (b) sustainable and equality-focused investing. As we first published several years ago, we define gender lens investing (GLI) as investing *in* women, *by* women, and *for* women. With progress on closing ever-present global economic and financial gender gaps stalling in recent years, we see continued opportunities to direct resources across the capital markets spectrum towards women borrowers, gender equality projects, the incorporation of social equality into all environmental and climate-related investing, and towards workplaces that walk the equality-promotion walk on representation in all levels of workforce and leadership, pay, and policies.

In the face of political pushback against equality, underrepresented populations remain partially or fully excluded from economic and financial participation in all global regions. Despite pressures on sustainable investing, investor demand for it remains strong. At Parallelle Finance, we will continue providing research and consulting services around sustainable investing, as well as investment advisory services.

- ❖ The report begins with *News from the Field,* following from International Women's Month. The latest data on financial and economic gender gaps demonstrate stalled progress on many fronts, including for women in corporate leadership.
- ❖ We follow with a discussion of *2025 sustainable investing trends*, including continued strong demand from investors.
- ❖ In addition, the report includes our quarterly update on equality-focused equity funds. A small group of technology stocks continued its narrow leadership of U.S. and global equity markets during the fourth quarter. In equality-related equities, AUM for publicly traded *gender lens equity funds (GLEFs)* totaled *$4.5 billion in AUM* as of December 31, 2024. With a slight downward tick, AUM growth was largely flat for the quarter.
- ❖ *Diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) equity funds* totaled *US$2.0 billion in AUM* as of December 31, 2024. AUM growth was flat for the fourth quarter. These funds focus on investing in companies with robust DEI policies or social justice track records.

We announce the results of our analysis of global AUM in gender lens investing across the capital markets spectrum. This includes available AUM data in segments of both public and private GLI asset classes. (See *Insert* after Section 2)

We estimate that global GLI investment assets totaled at least $122 billion as of March 31, 2025.

AUM in Gender bonds reached $57.1 billion as of December 31, 2024. Parallelle Finance expanded Gender bond types are the following. (See *Section 3* for AUM and our definitions of each type.)

- Use-of-proceeds primary Gender bonds
- Use-of-proceeds component Gender bonds
- Performance-based Gender bonds
- ➢ Wider scope (not included in AUM): ICMA, SDG, ESG aligned bonds that exhibit allocations not specified pre-issuance.

In addition to Gender bonds, our database includes $1 billion in gender lens bond funds, notes, and certificates available to individual investors, bringing the AUM in our coverage universe of *gender lens fixed income to $58 billion as of December 31, 2024*.

With this edition, we introduce expanded AUM data and classifications on Gender bonds – equality-focused sustainable bond issuances.

Section 1: The Women's Economy: International Women's Month – News from the Field

In late 2024 UN Women disseminated its theme for International Women's Day (IWD), March 8, 2025: For ALL women and girls: Rights. Equality. Empowerment.[1] This year marked the 30th anniversary of the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action, an enduring roadmap for global progress toward gender equality adopted in 1995 by 189 countries.[2] Since the Beijing Declaration, laws against gender-based violence have increased across the globe, women's access to health, housing, legal, and other essential services has expanded, and over 100 countries with action plans on women, peace, and security. But progress for women, especially in the global economy, has been uneven and frustratingly slow. With overlapping global gender gaps remaining stubbornly in place, the latest gender analysis by the World Economic Forum estimates it will take over 130 years to close economic, political, and health gaps.[3] The International Labour Organization (ILO) estimates that achieving gender parity in global employment alone will take 190 years at the current pace.[4]

A selection of gender equality data and studies are published each year in the months leading up to IWD. The following are highlights of the latest research around women in the global economy and workplace. See also ***Appendices A and B*** for data tables.

Women in the Global Economy: Persistent Gender Gaps

- BIG NEWS out of Australia: Gender equality efforts will play a central role in the country's foreign policy, trade, and aid programs. In recognition of the global economic benefits of gender equality and the persistence of economic, financial, political, and health and safety gender gaps, the Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade has issued Australia's International Gender Equality Strategy, demonstrating clear leadership on advancing global equality.[5] Through existing and new initiatives, the Strategy is centered around five priorities: (1) work to end sexual and gender-based violence and protect women's sexual and reproductive health and rights, (2) pursue gender responsive peace and security efforts, (3) deliver gender equitable climate action and humanitarian assistance, (4) promote women's economic equality and inclusive trade, and (5) support locally led approaches to women's leadership. The Strategy includes a focus on fostering equality throughout the Indo-Pacific region.
- World Bank Group (WBG) Gender Strategy 2024-2030: Gender equality is an urgent imperative. The global multilateral bank's gender strategy expresses a bold goal to accelerate gender equality in the next five years to end poverty and raise productivity and prosperity in the global economy – not to mention to address climate change in order to protect a livable planet.[6] The strategic objectives of the strategy are based around ending gender-based violence (GBV), expanding and enabling economic opportunities, and engaging women as leaders. As a multilateral institution, WBG will implement the strategy in an engagement model of country partnership frameworks involving innovative financing and institution-level reforms.

Psst… Start with yourself, WBG board… Currently only 5 out of 25 board members are women. This is well below parity and even below current broad market averages for public companies.

- Globally, 46.4% of working age women are employed versus 69.5% of men, according to the ILO. In the 30 years since the Beijing Declaration, this gap has been reduced by only four percentage points, with this small reduction driven mostly by a decline in the male employment rate. What does ILO data show about the drivers of economic gender gaps? Unpaid care work is the primary contributor to the gender employment gap. Women perform 76% of unpaid care work globally. Care responsibilities account for 45% of women outside the labor force globally, compared to 5% of men. Women with no children have a 68% labor force participation rate (LFPR), while men with no children have a 90.6% rate. For women with a child under six, the LFPR is 56.3%, compared to 94.5% for men with a child under six. With unpaid care burdens, ILO data shows that women are overrepresented in lower paying and vulnerable work. Unadjusted (average) pay gaps are the result. Employed women still earn 77.4 cents on the dollar to men's earnings, increasing slowly from 70.1 cents twenty years ago. When they do work, women are 1.6 times more likely to experience sexual violence or harassment at work.

When they retire, they face retirement income gaps, as 63.2% of men above mandatory retirement age receive a pension, while only 49.2% of women do.[7]

- The World Bank's *Women, Business and the Law* (WBL). This groundbreaking annual report is skipping a year in 2025 and will publish the next edition in 2026. The data from 2024 showed alarming law-related gender gaps, with only 14 countries providing women with the same legal rights and protections as men. Globally, women benefit from only two-thirds the legal rights as men. On the financial front, in 81 economies women's pension benefits do not account for work absences due to childcare. What's more, a full 62 economies have a women's retirement age that is earlier than men's, and only 15% of economies provide incentives that affect women's retirement benefits.[8] *Pension gaps + never-ending gender pay gaps = significant gender wealth gaps.*
- World Bank research connects dots on politics and labor force participation rates (LFPR). We write a lot about closing the gender gap in labor force participate rates (LFPR). According to WBL, closing the LFPR gender gap could serve to raise global GDP by at least 20%. The WBL project recently joined with Oliver Wyman Forum and Women Political Leaders to examine the impact of women's political representation on LFPR for women. The *Representation Matters* report spotlighted that higher representation for women in political decision-making is correlated with improvements in women's economic and legal rights.[9] Women are more likely to participate in the workforce if legal protections against discrimination and harassment, as well as in support of working families, are in place. Dots connected. But… While almost half of the world's population had government elections in 2024, women did not make meaningful gains in representation.
- How are economic gender gaps looking in Europe? The 2025 Report on Gender Equality in the EU summarizes gender gaps in several areas, including gender-based violence, leadership in society, and economic gaps based on the most recent 2023 data. The economic gender gap data showed that more than half of women with children under 12 spent at least five hours per day on child care work, compared to a quarter of men. Women were also more likely than men to provide informal long-term care for family members, with 41% of women providing the most personally demanding family care work, compared to 16% of men. Unpaid care work continues to drive a labor force participation gender gap throughout the region (80% for men vs. 70% for women), with an even higher gap for people with children, and a higher representation of women in part time work. The data also showed persistent gender segregation in the labor market, with women overrepresented in sectors marked by lower average pay. In contrast, men held 81% of higher-paying technology roles in the EU as a whole. The EU average unadjusted pay gap stood at 12% – higher than 10% in most countries, with eight countries coming in higher than 15%. What do lifelong pay and labor force gaps result in? Here, the data was stark. The 2023 average pension gender gap stood at 25%. This means women aged 65-79 received pensions that were 25% less than men in the same age group, with several countries turning in pension gender gaps above 30%.

> **"The home is the most dangerous place for women and girls."**
>
> This is according to a UN report released in late 2024 for the 25th annual International Day for the Elimination of Violence Against Women.[10] The corresponding UN Spotlight Initiative has pushed countries to adopt or enhance over 500 laws and policies and has provided essential services to three million women. But in 2023 an average of 140 women and girls were killed by partners or family members every day – one every ten minutes. Sima Bahous, Executive Director of UN Women noted that while progress has been made, "It is too slow, and it is threatened by emerging challenges from the political to the technological." No region has adequately addressed this global issue, with Africa seeing the highest number of victims per capita, followed by the Americas.

Women in the Global Workplace – Long Road Ahead

- Forbes Global Best Companies for Women 2024. This annual list of the 400 best global corporations for women, compiled by Forbes and Statista, is derived from anonymous responses to surveys of 100,000 women working for multinational corporations in 37 countries.[11] An assessment of the percentage of women in leadership at each company is also incorporated. Of the top 25 companies, there are six each headquartered in the U.S. and the U.K., with four based in France and three in Germany. No industries were dominant in the top 25, which included only Citigroup from banking and financial services. The top ten companies for 2024 were: Hilton Worldwide Holdings, MAIF, Douglas, Virgin Group, Netflix, Rio Tinto, Sappi, Microsoft, Generali Group, and Deloitte.

- When a number as low as 11.6% representation is a record high for women. Women's C-suite representation at the world's largest corporations lags badly behind the hard-fought progress of improved board representation. Heading into 2025, women CEOs of Fortune 500 companies have inched up to 11.6% after several years at the just-over-10% level. This means there are 58 women CEOs in the Fortune 500. One issue with low CEO representation is that one or two departures serve to tick the number back down, as we have seen occur regularly over the past five years.

- The Diversity Leaders 2025 is a Financial Times – Statista ranking evaluates Europe's top 850 companies for inclusion and equality.[12] Employee survey results comprise 70% of the scores, with the remaining 30% based on new indicators for this year: (a) the share of women in leadership and management, (b) diversity-related communications, and (c) a diversity score calculated by data provider Denominator. What does a look at the top 30 reveal? This top tier is dominated by 13 U.K. companies. France has five companies in the top 30, Germany has four, and Switzerland has three. Including insurers, there are nine financial services providers in the top 30, with a range of other industries represented.

- "Glacial rate of change." In its ninth annual edition, The Pipeline's Women Count 2024[13] found that only 9% of CEOs in the FTSE 350 Index constituents are women – a figure that has inched up from 5% in 2018. Despite comprising half the U.K. workforce, women make up only a third of FTSE 350 executive committee positions, with 2024 seeing a tick downward from 33% to 32%. Women CFOs are stuck at 18%, even though women make up 45% of certified accountants in the U.K. The report emphasizes that the business case for gender diversity in the workplace is "compelling," as we have frequently reported. Nonetheless, less than 20% of executive committee profit and loss roles are held by women in the index companies. The report identified four areas that drive progress for corporations: lead from the top, change the culture, drive accountability, and refrain from declaring victory too soon. At this pace, women's representation on FTSE 350 executive committees will not reach parity for another five generations.

Workplaces and the economy are losing out on the proven superior financial and operational performance associated with higher levels of diversity.

- Another example of women's leadership data going in the wrong direction. The FTSE Women's Leadership Review is the latest iteration of a longstanding independent, U.K. government-supported initiative for FTSE 350 companies to achieve targets for women on corporate boards. With the latest data release, FTSE 100 (43%) and FTSE 250 (42%) boards have met the target levels of women's representation, but troubling trends lurk underneath the headline numbers. For the FTSE 250, there was a decline in the number of women holding executive positions, and there is a growing gap between the number of women in non-executive director and executive roles. Women only represent 12% of FTSE 250 executives, with declining numbers in CEO and CFO roles.[14] Despite progress on boards – still not parity – a glass ceiling is still in place at these index constituents.

Investors are missing out on the proven financial and operational benefits of gender diversity in leadership, which doesn't mean limited to non-executive leadership.

- Less than 1% representation. Women CEOs are 0.8% of the over 1,600 companies on the Tokyo Stock Exchange's Prime Market. That is 13 women CEOs out of 1,643 top-tier Japanese listed companies. This is a far distance from the 2030 target of 30% executive women that the Japanese government has set for listed companies. As of 2023, only 122 companies have achieved that target, and 68 still had no women among their executive ranks.[15] While Japan has made better progress on women on boards, overall percentages remain in the teens. In the World Economic Forum's Global Gender Gap Report 2024, Japan ranked 118 out of 146 countries, with a low ranking of 120 on the economic participation and opportunity subindex, and a rank of 113 on political empowerment.[16]

- More work ahead for women in leadership at the Big Four audit firms. Gender parity in partnerships at these firms is still a long way off, despite goals set by each of them. PwC is three percentage points short of its 2025 goal of 30% of partnerships in the U.K. to be held by women, with progress only happening at one to two points per year. EY's goal of 40% women's representation in U.K. partnerships by this year is well short at 28%. Neither firm has set a global target for women's representation. KPMG surpassed its goal of 25% U.K. representation with 29% representation in 2023, but it will miss its 2025 global target. Deloitte achieved 30% partner representation in the U.K. in 2023 but is also on track to fall short of its global target for this year.[17] At this rate, how will parity be reached for these global corporate leaders?

Without women at parity in all senior roles, the relentless gender pay gap will not be closed. The formula for success is not complicated: Hire women, retain them with policies supportive of working families, promote them, pay them…promote them again.

Unique workforce inequities in the U.S. – still lagging on support for working families

- As International Women's Month came to an end, the U.S. remained the only OECD country without mandated paid family and caregiving leave. Globally, 98% of countries have paid maternity leave, with an average length of 18 weeks.[18]
- Payscale has released its 2025 Gender Pay Gap Report – a leading annual analysis of U.S. gender pay gap data. The unadjusted pay gap, which compares the median pay of all men and all women, shows that women earn 83 cents for every dollar earned by men in the U.S. This 17% gender pay gap is unchanged from last year. What does the unadjusted gender pay gap demonstrate? Women are overrepresented in lower-paying jobs, while high-paying jobs are predominantly held by men. In other words, structural inequalities in the workplace. In a persistent trend, the gender pay gap for parents is even wider, with median earnings of women who are parents coming in 25% lower than the median earnings of men who are parents. Women who are not parents confront a 12% unadjusted gender pay gap. How does the gender pay gap look when race is accounted for? Black women have a 21% gender pay gap versus White men, while the corresponding gap for Hispanic women is 22%, and American Indian women earn 25% less than White men. Asian women face a 5% median pay gap. The data also shows that women remain less likely to climb to higher workplace ranks than men, and that the progression for women is slower. For women who do reach the executive level, the median gender pay gap actually widens – to a steep 28%.[19]

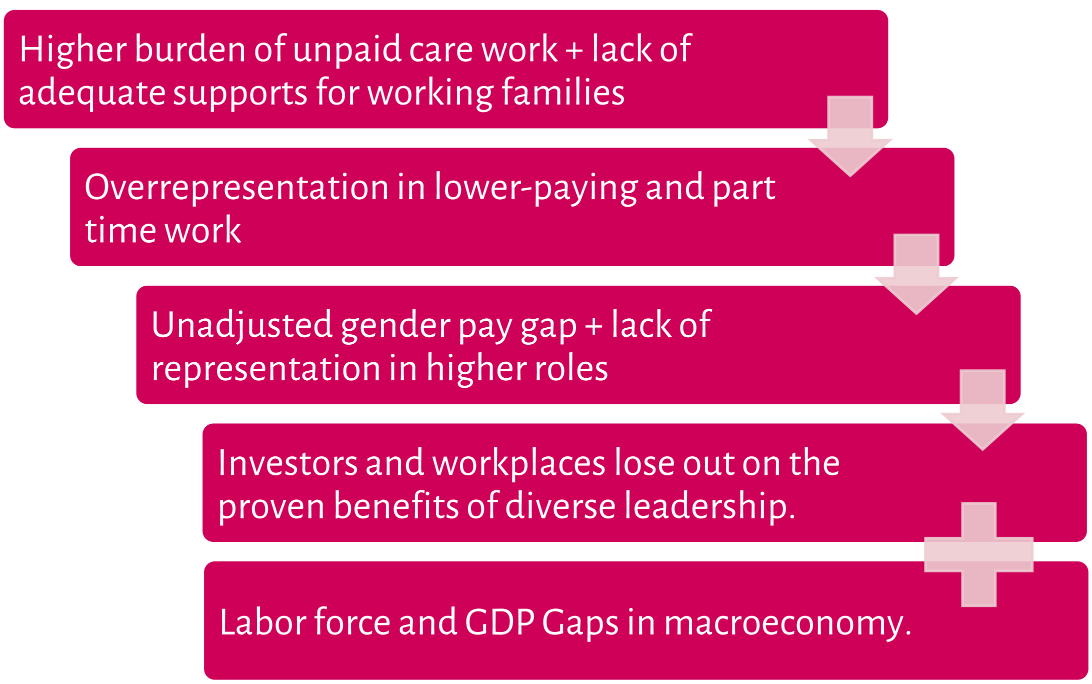
In the U.S., women had to work until March 25, 2025 to earn what men did in 2024.

- Five years post-pandemic, how do the unique inequities of the U.S. workforce look? ? The Institute for Women's Policy Research has summarized several trends and dynamics. On the plus side, women's employment recovered to pre-pandemic levels by early 2023 (that took longer than the recovery in men's employment), and women have increased their representation in some higher-paying industries by early 2025, including transportation and construction. On the minus side, women in the U.S. economy continue to perform and outsized share of unpaid care work. The Institute's research found that women are currently spending 6.7 hours per day on caregiving, compared to 5.6 hours per day for men. That adds up. Moreover, the gender gap in labor force participation rates for parents remain largely unchanged from pre-pandemic levels, with 94.9% of male parents in the labor force, versus only 73.7% of female parents.[20]
- Labor force participation for working women with children in the U.S. is lagging. While the LFPR for prime-age women (25-54) in the U.S. rose in 2024 to match historic record highs, the increase hides some important underlying dynamics. For starters, as 2025 got underway, the LFPR for all women remained below historic highs, stagnating for several years. The rates for both age ranges is still below the men's rates. But the real catch is what has happened for women with young children. Women in the U.S. with children under five turned in LFPR growth of 3.7 percentage points while pandemic-related federal child care subsidies were in place. After these ended in late 2023, creating the so-called child care cliff, the LFPR for women with children under five fell 1.4 percentage points in 2024 – but with rates declining the least in those states that provide child care funding. The rate for women with children age five to 18 continued on an upward

trajectory.[21] While the U.S. LFPR for prime-age women has recovered to near 80% during 2024 from a pandemic-era low of 74%, the LFPR has been declining for prime-age women with children under five has been declining since mid-2023, dipping below 70%.

Supportive policies for working families narrows overlapping financial gender gaps.

- Thus, the high cost of childcare in the U.S. has reversed post-pandemic gains in LFPRs for mothers (not fathers) with young children. How does the cost of childcare compare to rent in the largest 100 cities? Recent research by LendingTree uncovered a troubling direction in the cost of care. First, the average cost of full-time care for one infant is higher than the average rent for a two-bedroom apartment in 16 of the 100 largest cities. But when examining the average monthly cost of childcare for two children under five, this exceeds average two-bedroom rent in a stunning 91 of the 100 largest metro areas. In fact, it is nearly 40% higher.[22]
- Lo and behold, a recent survey by Care.com found that U.S. child care costs rose steeply in 2024. The cost of a home-based child care center rose to $344 per month for one infant, and the monthly cost of after-school care for two children is now $322. The average parent in the U.S. spends 22% of household income on child care, with an additional 18% spent on the care of older loved ones, pets, and the home. The stress of finding and managing care is high, with the average parent managing five different care resources.[23]



Section 2: Sustainable Investing Trends

2025 Metrics and Trends

What are the 2025 trends shaping sustainable investing in the U.S.? The latest trends report from the US Sustainable Investing Forum (US SIF) offers insights. Sustainable Investing is positioned for continued growth, with 73% of survey respondents conveying expectations that the market will grow strongly over the next several years. Even with increased political and regulatory scrutiny, growth is slated to be driven by client demand, regulatory changes, and improved data. A focus on improving data analytics and impact measurement is expected to help overcome challenges around political rhetoric, as is the growth in sustainable asset classes products, including private equity and thematic bonds. Climate solutions remains the leading investment strategy in the sector, reported as a key theme by 61% of respondents. Financial inclusion was cited by 35%, behind affordable housing, sustainable agriculture, social equity, and several other investment themes. Investment offerings are increasingly aligned with the 17 Sustainable Development Goals, with reduced inequalities (SDG 10) and gender equality (SDG 5) coming in third and sixth among current focus areas. ESG integration, the stated consideration of ESG factors in portfolio construction, and negative screens, the ruling out of certain industries, products, or services in portfolio construction, are the most widely used investment approaches, with fossil fuels dominating the list of top negative screens.[24]

AUM in global sustainable funds reached a record high of $3.2 trillion at the end of 2024.

Of Morningstar's six 2025 sustainable investing trends, the one that catches our eye is the forecast for continued strong growth in sustainable bonds, with issuances expected to exceed $1 trillion in a lower interest rate environment. (See Section 3.)

Morningstar has identified six 2025 trends to watch in ESG, or sustainable, investing. First up is the regulatory environment, particularly the first round of reporting under the EU's Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive, with pressure on regulators to show the value of the EU's first-mover policies. While regulatory actions in the U.S. may pull back support for sustainable investing, elsewhere the rollout of regulations will continue, including from the International Sustainability Standards Board. The second trend is the impact of the rollout of ESG fund naming rules, again particularly in Europe, where Morningstar expects up to 50% of ESG funds to undergo name changes. In the U.S., fund closures are expected to continue, while AUM maintains a growth trajectory. Additional trends to watch are increased investment in the low-carbon transition, biodiversity finance, and the increased environmental and social risks of AI. Green bonds, including growth in green-enabling issuances and EU market growth supported by EU voluntary enhanced reporting, are expected to maintain leadership in sustainable bond AUM for the year. Social bonds are expected to turn in solid AUM for second place.[25]

In terms of inflows and AUM, Morningstar found that the fourth quarter saw the highest inflows of 2024 for global ESG funds at $16 billion. Europe led the way at $18.5 billion, while the U.S. registered outflows ($4.3 billion), in keeping with the previous quarters. In looking at annual inflows since the significant peak in 2021, the following year saw a sharp pullback due to the challenging environment for bonds, with 2023-4 inflows even more subdued while remaining in positive territory.[26]

How are regulations driving change in sustainable funds? Corporate disclosure requirements have been moving ahead in Europe, although the timing of requirements appears to have been extended as of early 2025. In terms of funds, all publicly traded funds domiciled in the E.U. now carry a classification from the Sustainable Finance Disclosure Regulation. Article 9 funds employ stated objectives around sustainable investing. An Article 8 fund promotes environmental and/or social characteristics and must ensure that fund holdings reflect this.

How do trends in impact investing compare? The global impact investment market has reached $1.57 trillion in 2024, up from $1 trillion in 2022. The Global Impact Investing Network (GIIN) recently released its latest state of the market report, which also highlights a strong compound annual growth rate of 14% over the last five years. The survey included over 300 impact investors with a collective $490 billion in impact assets under management (AUM) and an average impact AUM of $1.6 billion. Three-quarters of these investors were investment managers (73%), followed by foundations (10%), and development finance institutions (4%). A significant majority of investors were headquartered in developed markets, including 72% in the U.S., Canada, and (non-eastern) Europe. Where does public gender lens investing fit in? The survey showed growth in impact investors who allocate the majority of investments in publicly traded equity and fixed income.[27]

GIIN defines impact investments as those "made with the intention to generate positive, measurable social and/or environmental impact alongside a financial return." How does this differ from ESG, or sustainable, investing? ESG describes both portfolio investment criteria and a set of non-financial corporate metrics on environmental, social, and governance issues. As such, ESG/sustainable investment is centered on targeting or excluding investee metrics.

Investor Demand

According to a new survey of over 900 institutional investors by Morgan Stanley's Institute for Sustainable Investing, 80% of asset managers and owners view sustainable investments as growth opportunities – and therefore they expect sustainable AUM to rise in the next two years. Asset managers expect demand for sustainable investing from new and existing clients, and asset owners report being prepared to switch asset managers in search of sustainable investment offerings. More than 80% of global asset owners require asset managers to offer sustainable investments, with 75% saying this is a key factor in manager selection/retention. Close to 90% of institutional investors report that their sustainable investing activities are driven by demand from their stakeholders. Renewable energy, energy efficiency, and climate adaptation rank among the high priority areas for investors. In terms of current sustainable investment strategies, health care and financial inclusion rank highest. For investors, sustainability data is the biggest challenge, outranking negative perceptions about sustainable investing.[28]

In another take on demand for sustainable investing offerings, Morningstar recently published its third annual survey of asset owners/managers throughout North America, Europe, and Asia-Pacific. Every asset manager reported allocating some portion of their assets to strategies with environmental, social, and governance (ESG) factors. 35% reported allocating at least half of their assets with taking ESG into account, up from 29% in 2022. A full two-thirds stated that ESG has become more material over the past five years. Across all survey regions, active ownership is viewed by nearly 80% of respondents as a key driver of implementing ESG investing, with direct engagement with companies ranked as the top method of active ownership. The most material environmental factor was climate transition readiness, consistent with previous surveys. Labor practices was the top material social factor cited by respondents, with business ethics coming in as the most material governance factor. Continued improvements in ESG data, ratings, and indexes remain on the minds of institutional investors, although respondents reported improvements in the last five years.[29]

Gender Lens: Equality-focused Sustainable Investing

We could not agree more: Climate finance initiatives must place gender equality front and center. A report by Brookings sounds the alarm on the latest global initiatives to reform climate finance. While there is recognition that total global climate finance is falling short of what is required by developing economies, global initiatives are busy announcing that a significant increase in funding is needed from multilateral and private sector institutions, but failing to name gender equality as a priority. For example, debt relief efforts should include a focus on helping governments fund the public services on which women are more reliant than men. In addition to the ongoing focus on mitigation, adaptation finance is needed, including for clean technologies for women-dominated small-scale agriculture. Often best positioned to serve as leaders of local climate solutions, women need much more access to the private capital needed to pursue entrepreneurship to create innovative products and services for their communities.[31]

As cited by the Brookings report[30] - with backing from our data - Gender bonds can play a big role in financial inclusion for women working in climate solutions in both mitigation and adaptation. (See Section 3.)

A longtime leader in responsible and sustainable investing, Calvert Research and Management recently celebrated the 20th anniversary of the Calvert Women's Principles, the first corporate code of conduct with a focus on advancing, protecting, and investing in women. As **numerous studies have since demonstrated**, gender diversity is associated with superior financial, operational, and risk-management results for corporations on a wide range of metrics. The key workplace-centered areas of the Calvert Women's Principles are designed to help companies reap those benefits while also addressing economy-wide gender gaps: (1) employment and compensation, (2) work-life balance and career opportunities, (3) health, safety, and freedom from violence, (4) management and governance, (5) business, supply chain, and marketing practices, (6) civic and community engagement, and (7) transparency and accountability.

Since the landmark principles were instituted by Calvert, gains for women on corporate boards have been made through sustained shareholder pressure and mandates, while progress in other areas, including representation in management and executive ranks, has lagged.

The Gender Lens Investing Market: Estimated Global AUM of at least $122 billion.

Based on available data as of March 31, 2025

Public Markets GLI data points

Public equity funds (source: Parallelle Finance)

- AUM: $4.5 billion as of December 31, 2024
- Count: 43 funds globally as of December 31, 2024
- Growth: 22 of these funds were launched in the last 5 years (a 51% growth rate)
- Average fund age: 5.5 years; Holdings: 30 to over 375 stocks

A suite of gender lens equity funds has grown from over two decades of research demonstrating the performance and other corporate benefits of higher levels of women-in-leadership (WIL). Fund criteria are centered around investing in companies demonstrating leadership on a range of gender equality metrics. **See here for a list of all GLEFs by AUM along with performance**.

Fixed income (sources: Parallelle Finance, Luxembourg Green Exchange, Environmental Finance)

Parallelle Finance maintains a global dataset on Gender bonds, including comprehensive issuance characteristics and descriptions, including summary stats on sectors, currencies, and geographical data. With expanded categories and data, total AUM in Gender bonds reached $57.1 billion as of December 31, 2024. Parallelle Finance Gender bond categories are the following. (See ***Section 3*** for our definitions of each category.)

- Use-of-proceeds primary Gender bonds
- Use-of-proceeds component Gender bonds
- Performance-based Gender bonds
- Wider scope (not included in AUM): ICMA aligned bonds that exhibit significant allocations not specified pre-issuance.

With additional instruments, including bond funds, notes, and certificates, total AUM in gender lens fixed income was $58.0 billion as of December 31, 2024.

Under its designated gender flag, the **Luxembourg Green Exchange (LGX)** counted 169 listed gender-focused bonds outstanding as of February 2023. LGX estimated that this was 2% of listed sustainable bonds at that time. (https://www.luxse.com/discover-lgx/sustainable-securities-on-lgx/gender-focused-bonds/gender-finance-study)

Environmental Finance has estimated that 0.92% of sustainable bonds are aligned with SDG5. (https://www.environmental-finance.com/content/downloads/sustainable-bonds-insight-2025.html)

Separately managed accounts (SMA) (sources: Parallelle Finance and Veris Wealth Partners)

Separately managed accounts are portfolios of public equity and/or fixed income securities managed by an investment professional on behalf of an investor. **Parallelle Finance** research indicates approximately 20 gender lens equity and fixed income SMAs offered by global asset management firms, with over $1.9 billion in reported AUM as of March 31, 2025.

In 2021, **Veris Wealth Partners** identified $1 billion in AUM invested in 18 separately managed accounts and proprietary strategies with a gender lens as of 2021, up from $500 million (and 13 vehicles) in 2019. https://www.veriswp.com/the-data-shows-gender-lens-investing-is-growing-there-is-more-work-to-do/

In other GLI portfolios of publicly traded equities, the Government Pension Investment Fund (GPIF) of Japan has made substantive investments in the asset class. According to its latest annual ESG report, as of March 31, 2024 the GPIF held $15.6 billion (approx. 1% of its total holdings) in gender lens equities through portfolios aligned with the following indexes:

- MSCI Japan Empowering Women Index ("WIN") - JPY940.3B ($6.21B)
- Morningstar Japan ex-REIT Gender Diversity Tilt Index ("GenDi J") - JPY736.4B ($4.86B)
- Morningstar Developed Markets Ex-Japan Gender Diversity Index ("GenDi") - JPY684.9B ($4.52B)

Private Markets GLI data points

Development Finance Institutions: Catalyzing Capital (source: 2X Global)

The third round of the 2XChallenge, a groundbreaking gender finance initiative, was announced in June 2024. G7 development finance institutions have pledged to invest $20 billion in financing for women's empowerment over the next three years. The 2X Challenge initiative began in 2018 with a commitment by G7 DFIs to invest $3 billion with a gender equality lens while mobilizing private investment participation. The first round of the Challenge exceeded its goal and was followed by a 2021 round of commitments, which also surpassed targets. As of reporting in mid-2024, $33.6 billion in gender lens investments have been made by the DFIs and private investors under the initiative. For the latest Challenge of $20 billion between 2024-27, a collection of private funds has joined the commitment. (https://www.2xchallenge.org/)

*Venture Capital and Private Funds (equity/debt) funds (sources: Pitchbook and Project Catalyst)**

According to **Pitchbook** data, venture capital (VC) investment in women-only founder teams in the U.S. remained at a longtime level of 2.1% as of December 31, 2024, raising $3.7 billion for the year, with Europe women-only founder teams at 1.5% (€814.6 million) of total VC capital in Europe in 2024. Gender-diverse founder teams in the U.S. garnered 20.9% of total venture investments in 2024, down significantly from a 2023 peak of 23.9%. Corresponding teams in Europe pulled in 28.8%. https://pitchbook.com/news/articles/the-vc-female-founders-dashboard

The April 2024 survey of **Project Catalyst** (formerly Project Sage) published summary data from 159 private funds that integrate a gender lens into the investment process. June 30, 2023, AUM in these vehicles was at least $7.9 billion. (The June 2021 iteration of this survey highlighted a suite of funds with total AUM of $6.0 billion.) In the latest survey results, 40% of the funds represented a second gender lens fund, and 10% reported AUM of at least $500 million. A high majority of vehicles in the dataset were venture capital equity funds. https://www.2xglobal.org/knowledge-hub-blog/projectcatalyst

**In order to avoid potential double-counting, the Project Catalyst figure is included in the above total AUM.*

Section 3: Gender Lens Fixed Income

Overview of Sustainable Bonds

According to the International Capital Market Association (ICMA), the four labels of sustainable bonds are Green, Social, Sustainability, and Sustainability-linked bonds, also known as GSSS. These fit into two categories. The first category is use-of-proceeds (UoP) bonds, which have three types:

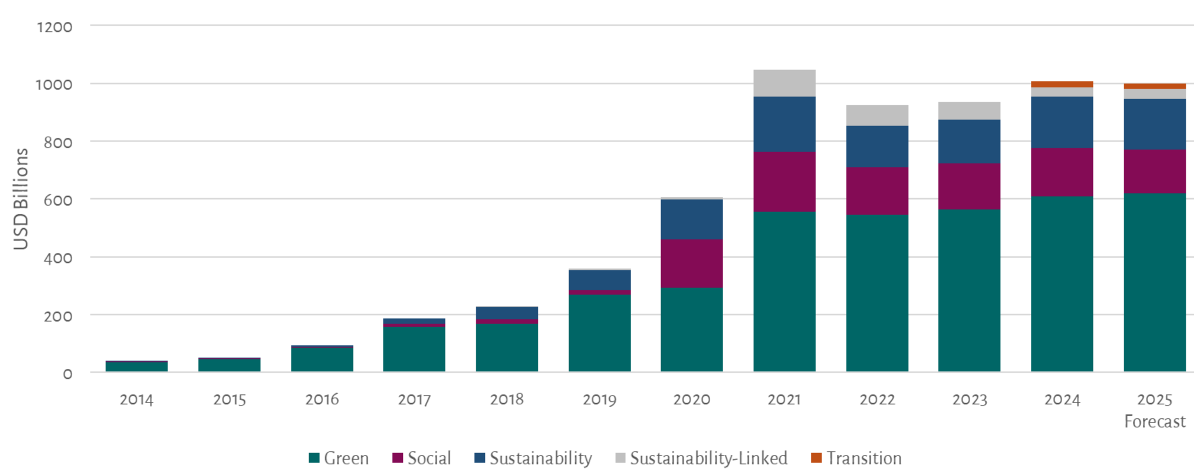
- Green: Instruments that raise funds for projects with environmental benefits. These are described in ICMA's Green Bond Principles (GBP).
- Social: Instruments that raise funds for projects to address a social issue or to achieve a positive social outcome. This can include access to financing, education, gender equality, or health care for target populations. These are described in ICMA's Social Bond Principles (SBP).
- Sustainability: Instruments that raise funds for projects with both environmental and social targets. These are described in ICMA's Sustainability Bond Guidelines (SBG).

Use-of-proceed gender bonds fall within the ICMA Social or Sustainability categories. Among Sustainability-linked bonds, there are a growing number of issuances employing gender equality targets. (See below.)

The second ICMA category is Sustainability-linked bonds, which are described in ICMA's Sustainability-linked Bond Principles (SLBP). Also known as performance-based bonds, these are any type of instrument for which the financial characteristics can vary according to whether the issuer achieves predefined sustainability objectives. The issuer goals employed by these bonds are key performance indicators (KPIs), with accompanying sustainability performance targets (SPTs) established from issuer baselines.

Moody's has predicted that annual AUM in the global GSSS market will reach $1 trillion in 2025, in line with the 2024 market, with the negative impact from U.S. politics being overruled by a continued strong focus on sustainable debt globally. Notably, Moody's forecasts a record of $650 million in Green bond issuances for the year, with the segment maintaining its longtime leadership. Focus areas, including from private U.S. issuers, are expected to include green energy, emerging green technologies, climate adaptation and resilience, and ecosystems conservation. The forecast for Social bonds is a modest decline to $150 billion, and Sustainability bond issuances are anticipated to keep steady at $175 billion. Sustainability-linked bonds are expected to see growth of 14% to $35 billion. Transition bonds, an emerging category of issuances which finance corporate transitions to the green economy, are forecasted to remain flat at $20 billion.[32]

Figure 3.1: GSSS bond market issuance volume (as of December 31, 2024)



Source: Climate Bond Initiative 2014-2019; Moody's 2020 and thereafter

Gender bonds: a focus on gender equality or women's empowerment

The Parallelle Finance coverage universe incorporates a suite of gender lens fixed income (GLFI) funds and vehicles. These include U.S. and emerging markets funds, U.S. notes and certificates, and a lending platform. The GLFI asset class is dominated by Gender bonds, a thematic sustainable debt asset class comprised of private financial institution and corporate bond issues, development finance institution (DFI)-backed bonds, and agency- and DFI-issued bonds.

We maintain the leading global dataset of Gender bonds, with comprehensive metrics on each issuance. Our dataset includes Gender bonds from all global regions. Three global exchanges have led the way in listing Gender bonds from emerging and developed market issuers: Luxembourg Green Exchange (LGX), Singapore Stock Exchange, and London Stock Exchange. Gender bond issuers have found demand in nearly 40 currencies. Most of the bonds in our dataset are investment grade instruments.

Gender Lens Fixed Income Composition

The biggest GLFI regional allocation is in emerging markets. In looking at a representative composition of primary UoP Gender bonds, Asian emerging markets have a substantive allocation, representing bonds issued or supported by the Asian Development Bank (ADB) and the Women's Livelihood Bond Series issued by Impact Investment Exchange (IIX). Latin America has a strong and growing representation in Gender bonds, with a number supported by IDB Invest, the private sector arm of the Inter-American Development Bank (IDB). For all GLFI instruments by currency, the top countries are Canada, U.S., Australia, New Zealand, Norway, Eurozone, and United Kingdom. **See an interactive map and table summarizing GLFI AUM invested by country here.**

With this edition of our Review, we unveil expanded data on the categories and market size of Gender bonds. (See Figure 3.2)

Contact us for more information on Gender bond issuer types, currencies, regional AUM, and exchange listings.

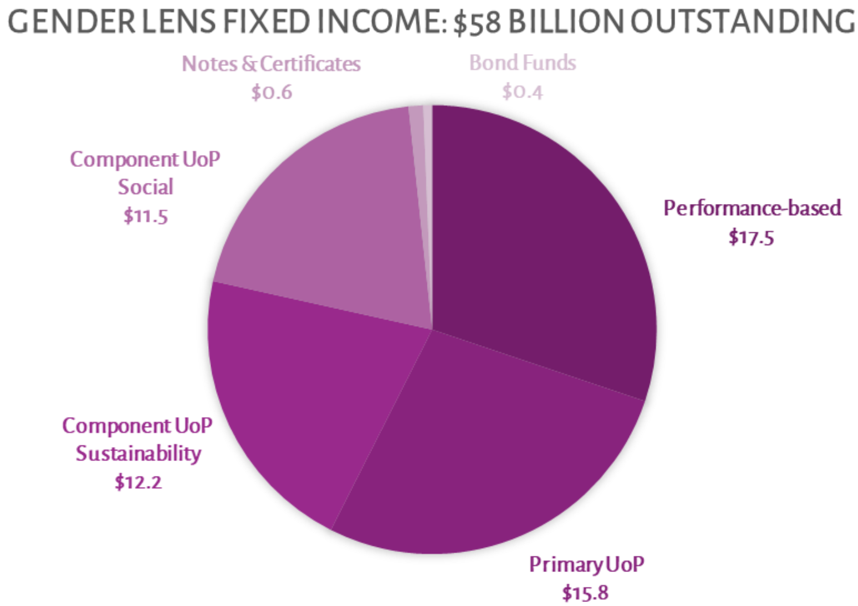
Market Update

Women borrowers and gender equality projects targeted by Gender bond issuances during the fourth quarter of 2024 included:

- Financing for women housing borrowers across Africa through a Social bond issued by Absa Group.
- The second Social bond by the African Development Bank, with women included in target population for financing.
- Loans for women-owned small and medium enterprises (SMEs) in Jordan through a Jodan Ahli Bank Sustainability Bond.
- The first of six Social bonds issued by Spain's Caixa Bank to include a focus on gender equality projects.
- The first primary UoP Gender bond in Kyrgyzstan, issued by the Asian Development Bank.

To wrap up a steady year for Gender bonds, the Japan International Cooperation Agency issued two Gender bonds with the approximately $200 million in funds to be allocated to new and ongoing commitments to gender equality.

Figure 3.2. Gender bonds: Outstanding AUM, Definitions, ICMA categories as of December 31, 2024.



How do we define and count Gender bonds? Within the two ICMA categories of UoP and performance-based bonds, three Gender bond types have allocations or KPIs centered on women borrowers or gender equality projects or targets *specified in the pre-issuance stage*. These types comprise our expanded total AUM:

Primary UoP Gender bonds: This is an issuance where the proceeds are majority or solely directed at (a) financing to women and other underrepresented borrowers for business, housing, transportation, or other essential services, (b) financing for health care or other essential services for women and other underrepresented populations, or (c) beneficial financing to corporate entities demonstrating leadership on gender equality. With the first issuance earlier in 2024, sovereign UoP Gender bonds direct proceeds toward these areas and also toward public sector programs to combat inequality and gender-based violence. *These fit the parameters of ICMA Social bonds.*

Component UoP Gender bonds: Within a wider scope, a growing number of broader-based Gender bonds include a stated focus or significant allocation on women borrowers or gender equality projects among several social and/or climate project areas. *These fit the parameters of ICMA Social or Sustainability bonds.*

Performance-based Gender bonds: A growing number of sovereign and corporate issuers include gender diversity objectives in the issuer goals employed by Sustainability-linked bonds. Typically, the proceeds for these bonds are general purpose. Key performance indicators (KPIs), with accompanying gender-focused sustainability performance targets (SPTs), are established from baseline gender metrics. *These fit the parameters of ICMA Sustainability-linked bonds.*

Beyond these three types, our research indicates additional Social, Sustainability, Sustainability-linked, SDG, or ESG bonds that exhibit the following: (a) mention of gender equality or social project categories at issuance *without specifying allocations*, and (b) *post-issuance demonstration* of notable allocation to women borrowers or gender equality projects. We also maintain a list of Green bonds with a gender-equality angle in project categories, geographical impact of projects, or in the gender diversity of issuance participants.

In addition to Gender bonds, our database includes $1 billion in gender lens bond funds, notes, and certificates available to individual investors, bringing the AUM in our coverage universe of gender lens fixed income to $58 billion as of December 31, 2024.

GLFI Use of Proceeds

The proceeds from GLFI funds and vehicles are directed at women-focused financing needs, including to:

- Advance the goals of United Nations Sustainable Development Goal 5.
- Finance women-owned enterprises in Latin America, South Asia and Southeast Asia.
- Finance companies with higher levels of WIL.
- Finance Women's Empowerment Principles (WEP) signatories and companies included in Equileap's annual ranking.
- Invest in fossil-free bonds with a gender lens.
- Provide housing financing for women in the U.S. and Latin America.
- Fund women-led rural businesses in Mexico.
- Expand loans to women in Mexico without raising rates.
- Direct funds to women's health initiatives and projects.
- Address the uneven impact of COVID-19 on women.
- Provide loan capital to women of color who own small businesses in the U.S.
- Invest in Nigerian companies with a female CEO.
- Provide access to clean, renewable energy to women in developing economies.
- Finance childcare providers in the U.S.
- Increase access to loans for U.S. women-led small businesses.
- Finance small and medium women-owned businesses in Canada.
- Provide housing financing for women in Kazakhstan, particularly in rural areas.
- Provide loans to women-owned microenterprises in Colombia.

Section 4: Equality-Focused Equities – Thematic Sustainable Investing

Gender Lens Equity Funds (GLEFs)

A suite of gender lens equity funds (GLEFs) has grown from over two decades of research demonstrating the performance and other corporate benefits of higher levels of women-in-leadership (WIL). GLEF criteria are centered around investing in companies with higher WIL levels and strong additional equality metrics, including pay equity and disclosure, gender diversity at all workforce levels, and policies supportive of retaining and promoting women. In our coverage universe, a GLEF is defined as employing at least one specified gender equality criterion in the core investment strategy. Most of these funds have a range of stated gender equality criteria as well as various broader sustainability screens or criteria. There are **43 GLEFs available to individual investors** : 23 global equity funds and 20 regional equity offerings, including 11 U.S. equity funds. As of December 31, 2024, assets under management (AUM) for the GLEF asset class was $4.5 billion. AUM growth was largely flat for the fourth quarter. For funds in our dataset in both periods, the 12-month period to December 31, 2024 saw slight growth in AUM.

Among the U.S.-domiciled offerings there are nine U.S. equity funds and two global equity funds. Europe is home to 20 GLEFs, including three Europe funds, one U.S. equity fund, and 16 global equity offerings. Six funds are domiciled in Canada, with three in Japan and one in Republic of Korea. There are three pairs of mutual funds/ETFs. With an average fund age of 5.5 years, eleven funds have over seven years of history, while ten funds have 5-7 years, nine have 3-5 years, and 12 have less than three years. The funds hold from 30 to over 375 stocks. **For key stats on these 43 funds, see here.**

See here for a list of all GLEFs by AUM.

Figure 4.1: Gender Lens Equity Index Groups

Gender Lens Equity Indexes	Description
Solactive Equileap	Global and regional gender lens equity indexes constructed from Equileap data. Equileap ranks publicly listed companies on 19 comprehensive gender equality criteria, including representation at all levels of the workforce and board, pay gap and transparency, workforce benefits, and anti-sexual harassment policies. Persistent gaps remain in all areas, including workforce metrics, with women's representation shrinking at each higher level of management. In April 2024 Solactive announced the launch of the Solactive Equileap Emerging Markets ex China A-Shares Gender Equality Index.
MSCI	A class of women's leadership indexes with a focus on women at board and leadership levels — and a U.S. gender diversity index based on a more robust set of leadership, workforce, and policy criteria.
FTSE Russell	Women's leadership indexes based on the Russell 1000 Index and the FTSE All-Share Index.
Morningstar	A family of gender lens indexes constructed from Equileap corporate gender equality scores.
Euronext	The Euronext Equileap Gender Equality France 40 and the Euronext Equileap Gender Equality Eurozone 100 indexes include companies that have demonstrated strength in advancing gender equality.

See index stats here.

Figure 4.2: 3- and 12-month GLEF performance: representative gender lens equity funds (as of December 31, 2024

AUM	Fund Name			Performance (%)	
(in $ mill)	***Broad Market Index***			3 month	1 year
$ 729.0	Impax Ellevate Global Women's Leadership Fund (investor class)	USD		0.29	12.08
	MSCI World Index (Net)	*USD*		*-0.16*	*18.67*
$ 651.7	Nordea 1 - Global Diversity Engagement Fund	USD		-3.64	16.68
	MSCI All Country World Index (Net)	*USD*		*-0.99*	*17.49*
$ 587.4	UBS Global Gender Equality UCITS ETF	USD		-5.12	8.69
	Solactive Equileap Global Gender Equality 100 Leaders Index	*USD*		*-5.07*	*8.54*
$ 292.3	Mirova Women Leaders and Diversity Equity Fund	EUR		1.33	19.40
	MSCI World Index (Net)	*EUR*		*7.61*	*26.60*
$ 249.0	SPDR MSCI USA Gender Diversity ETF	USD		1.61	23.32
	Russell 1000 Total Return Index	*USD*		*2.75*	*24.51*
$ 197.4	Desjardins Sustainable Diversity Fund	CAD		1.50	16.30
	MSCI All Country World Index (Gross)	*CAD*		*5.51*	*28.72*
$ 149.9	Fidelity Women's Leadership Fund	USD		-1.07	13.70
$ 4.6	Fidelity Women's Leadership ETF	USD		-1.50	12.90
	Russell 3000 Total Return Index	*USD*		*2.63*	*23.81*
$ 119.2	BMO Women in Leadership Fund	CAD		5.40	23.80
$ 5.4	BMO Women in Leadership Fund ETF	CAD		5.36	23.83
	S&P 500 Net Total Return Index	*CAD*		*8.91*	*35.80*

Source: Fund factsheets

Figure 4.3: 3- and 12-month GLEI performance

Index performance (%) as of December 31, 2024	3 months	1 year
Solactive Equileap Global Gender Equality NTR Index	**-5.7**	**7.3**
Solactive Equileap Global Gender Equality 100 Leaders NTR Index	**-5.1**	**8.5**
MSCI World Women's Leadership Index (Net)	**-3.7**	**8.6**
MSCI World Index (Net)	-0.2	18.7
MSCI All Country World Index (Net) (ACWI)	-1.0	17.5
Solactive Equileap Emerging Markets ex China A-Shares Gender Equality Index	**-10.1**	**4.8**
MSCI Emerging Markets Index (Net)	-0.1	7.5
Solactive Equileap US Gender Equality NTR Index	**-1.7**	**10.1**
Solactive Equileap US Select Gender Equality NTR Index	**-1.8**	**11.7**
Morningstar Women's Empowerment Net Return Index	**0.2**	**16.9**
MSCI USA Women's Leadership Index (Net)	**0.1**	**11.3**
MSCI USA Gender Diversity Select Index	**1.5**	**23.4**
Hypatia Womens CEO	**-2.3**	**9.8**
Pink Chip Index	**-2.9**	**9.4**
S&P 500 Net Total Return Index	2.3	24.5
Russell 3000 Total Return Index	2.6	23.8
Russell 1000 Total Return Index	2.8	24.5

Sources: Factsheets and website information

See the Parallelle Finance website for 3- and 12-month performance figures for the GLEFs, their benchmarks, and the gender lens equity indexes.

GLEF Composition

There were 164 unique top 10 holdings among the GLEFs as of December 31, 2024, according to publicly disclosed data. Of these, 93 were held in the global equity segment. Figure 4.4 highlights the top-ten companies held by the most funds, with Information Technology (IT) and Financials sharing the industry lead. Microsoft is a top holding in 24 of these funds. Of the other stocks in the most-held group, NVIDIA and Apple are top holdings for 17 funds. All three are among the technology stocks driving broad market performance over multiple recent periods ended December 31, 2024. In financials, Visa Inc. is held by 14 funds, with JP Morgan Chase, Mastercard, and S&P Global also represented.

Consistent with longstanding trends, 37% of the unique top holdings are represented in the Solactive Equileap family of indexes, a figure that shifts up to 44% for the global equity segment (with the expansion of the Equileap indexes into emerging markets). 90% of the top holdings are MSCI ACWI Index constituents.

Figure 4.4: Top 10 holdings in eight+ GLEFs (as of December 31, 2024)

Company	Number of Funds	Country	Sector
Microsoft	24	U.S.	Information Technology
Apple	17	U.S.	Information Technology
NVIDIA	17	U.S.	Information Technology
Visa Inc	14	U.S.	Financials
Eli Lilly	12	U.S.	Health Care
Alphabet	9	U.S.	Communication Services
JPMorgan Chase	9	U.S.	Financials
Accenture	8	Ireland	Information Technology
Amazon	8	U.S.	Consumer Discretionary
Mastercard	8	U.S.	Financials
S&P Global	8	U.S.	Financials

Sources: Fund and index fact sheets

Consistent with previous periods and with the MSCI All-Country World Index (ACWI), IT (23.4%) and Financials (18.6%) were top AUM-weighted sector allocations for the asset class as of December 31, 2024, as shown in *Figure 4.5*. A number of these funds hold one or more constituents of the top technology-related stocks driving market returns during 2023-4. IT leadership was pronounced in the U.S. equity segment at 30.6%. Health Care, Industrials, and Consumer Discretionary made up the rest of the top five sectors. Real Estate and Energy are not well represented in these funds. In looking at the data since 2020, these funds as a group display style consistency. Our data shows most allocation shifts over the periods happening in technology and the consumer segments.

Again consistent with prior periods and with the ACWI, AUM-weighted country allocations for the asset class have been and remain dominated by U.S. shares, as indicated in *Figure 4.6*, with a 64.6% weighting as of December 31, 2024. The U.K., Canada, France, and Australia round out the top five. How do the top country allocations for these funds compare to leading global rankings for corporations and economies? When we look at the Equileap global corporate rankings and the WEF Global Gender Gap 2024 scores, an interesting picture emerges. The U.K., France, Australia, and Germany all hold strong Equileap scores and place in the top-quartile of WEF rankings. The U.S. and Canada hold solid – but lower – rankings on both.

Figure 4.5: AUM-weighted sector allocations of GLEFs (as of December 31, 2024)

Sector	GLEFs (Dec 2024)	GLEFs (Dec 2020)	MSCI ACWI (Dec 2024)
Information Technology	23.4%	17.5%	26.0%
Financials	18.6%	17.6%	16.8%
Health Care	12.6%	11.8%	9.7%
Industrials	10.6%	9.5%	10.2%
Consumer Discretionary	10.4%	13.1%	11.3%
Consumer Staples	6.7%	10.1%	5.9%
Communication Services	6.7%	6.1%	8.2%
Utilities	3.0%	2.7%	2.5%
Materials	2.7%	4.9%	3.5%
Real Estate	1.6%	2.6%	2.0%
Energy	0.6%	0.7%	3.8%
Cash	1.4%	1.1%	0.0%
Unspecified	1.6%	2.4%	0.0%
Total	100.0%	100.0%	100.0%

Sources: Fund fact sheets, FT.com

Figure 4.6: AUM-weighted country allocations of GLEFs (as of December 31, 2024)

	GLEFs (Dec 2024)	GLEFs (Dec 2020)	MSCI ACWI (Dec 2024)	Equileap 2024 Rank (of 17 total)	WEF 2024 Rank (of 146 total)
U.S.	64.6%	57.8%	66.5%	14	43
U.K.	5.8%	5.1%	3.1%	3	14
Canada	4.1%	7.4%	2.7%	13	36
France	3.9%	6.2%	2.3%	1	22
Australia	2.6%	3.2%	1.5%	7	24
Japan	2.6%	2.5%	4.8%	15	118
Germany	1.4%	3.2%	1.9%	9	7
Netherlands	0.8%	1.6%	1.0%	12	20
Switzerland	0.8%	0.8%	2.0%		15
Denmark	0.8%	1.4%	0.0%	5	28
Other	12.6%	10.8%	14.2%		
Total	100.0%	100.0%	100.0%		

Sources: Fact sheets and FT.com

As we have previously advocated, we believe that the leading economic rankings of gender equality should encompass a "investment-in-women" score.

Quarterly Commentary

Fund Additions and Closures

During the quarter one new fund was launched and another was announced. There was one fund closure.

> Three cheers for this innovative fund, Future Generation Women, centered on investing by and in women!

The Future Generation Women fund was launched in early December and is available to Australian wholesale investors with a minimum investment of AUD250,000. Offered by the Future Generation Group, the fund invests in Australian and global market companies with relative strength in gender-diverse leadership, pay equality, and policies supportive of working families. Foregoing a management fee, the fund will donate 1% of AUM annually to non-profit entities focused on advancing gender equality. Notably, the fund has an all-women management team of Australian portfolio managers. Women comprise less than one-quarter of investment teams in Australia, with women's representation among portfolio managers declining from 23% in 2017 to 19% in 2024.

Also in early December, the Rock Creek Group announced the pending launch of the RockCreek Global Equality ETF. This global equity fund invests in gender equality leaders from developed and emerging markets, with the fund's investment universe derived from broad capitalization parameters. From there, investment criteria are rooted in Equileap gender equality scores of large listed companies in developed and emerging markets. Equileap's scores are based on a comprehensive set of gender equality metrics, including representation of women at all levels of leadership and workforce, gender pay gaps and transparency, supplier diversity, workplace policies around anti-sexual harassment and support for working families, and legal risks around gender controversies. In addition to ethical exclusions, the fund's investment process also include gender lens criteria based on work with the Equality Fund, a primarily philanthropic investment fund founded in 2018 with CAD300 million in support from the Government of Canada. ***Note: The RockCreek Global Equity ETF began trading on February 27, 2025. As such, the fund's AUM is not included in the GLEF total as of December 31, 2024.***

> We view the Equileap criteria as a leading foundation for the construction of gender lens equity funds and portfolios.

The IQ Engender Equality ETF was closed during the period. The fund tracked the Solactive Equileap U.S. Select Gender Equality Index.

Investing in Women News

Another in a long line of studies, this one from Bloomberg Intelligence (BI), has shown again that diverse leadership outperforms. Globally, women held 26% of board seats as of 2023, with Bloomberg data showing that women on S&P boards is around 35%. According to BI research on share price returns from 2010 to 2023, in developed markets the top 20% of companies for female board membership outperformed the bottom 20% by 2-5%. In emerging markets, the top 20% were 2-6% less volatile than the bottom 20%. Bloomberg forecasts board gender parity by 2030, which seems aggressive given the stall in the growth of women board members. As we have cited many times, women's representation in the C-suite badly lags progress at the board level, a dynamic that also merits sustained stakeholder pressure. The Bloomberg report cited continued diversity pressure on U.S. companies despite political headwinds.[33]

> One solution is clear: investing in women founders of women-focused products and services. We see a growing number of women-led funds doing just this. Having published it several years back, we never tire of saying it: Our definition of gender lens investing… Investing in women, for women, and by women.

Investing in women-focused products and services is $32 trillion opportunity, according to a recent global survey by Boston Consulting Group. The survey found that women, who are expected to control 75% ($38 trillion) of discretionary spending in the next five years, do not believe that products and services meet their needs in sectors such as consumer goods, health care, and financial services. The lowest ranking products and services were health insurance and health care, where only 37% and 44% of women reported the sector as meeting their needs. This was followed by low marks for a full range of financial services, where 44-47% of women gave the categories top marks. The highest ranking categories, groceries and personal care, only received top marks from 66% of women. Within women's health, menopause represents an estimated $600 billion opportunity. Women-led technology solutions around employee benefits, a $2.8 trillion market, is another area ripe for investment in women-led startups.[34]

Cheers for the launch of the Representation Index (RX). This is the first global tool to measure inclusivity in advertising and creative content. Launched by technology company XR Extreme Reach and The Female Quotient, the AI-powered metric analyzes age, gender expression, body type, and skin tone to provide scores by industry vertical, brand, campaign, and ad. The Female Quotient is a media company with a mission to raise women's visibility and promote gender equality in media and the workplace. With a majority-women team, the company partners with multiple corporations and offers Equality Lounge gatherings at leading global economic and industry events. The RX score will be expanded to include accessibility and authority as well. Representation matters, including in media and advertising. Inclusive gender equality means representation for all women in all areas of economic and public life.[35] We are all for this initiative and have our fingers crossed for publicly available data from the tool. But we could not help noticing that XR Extreme Reach has an all-male board and only one woman on its 4-person executive team. How does this demonstrate a commitment to inclusivity in the workplace and economy? (Answer: It does not.)

How do fund holdings compare to the broader market?

How well are the top holdings of these funds reflecting above-average WIL statistics? We update the following analysis annually.

Figure 4.7: Women in Leadership statistics for GLEF top 10 holdings (as of June 30, 2024)

Leadership Position	Count	Percentage of Total
CEO	22	13.9%
Chair	24	15.2%
More than one of the above	11	7.0%
None of the above	115	72.8%
Board parity (50%)	27	17.1%
Average female board members		36.0%
Average female executives		27.2%
Sources: GemmaQ for Fortune 500 companies; Company public disclosures		

Figure 4.7 summarizes key WIL metrics as of June 30, 2024, using the available data on GLEF top ten holdings. Consistent with previous quarters, the analysis indicates these funds are capturing higher-than-average WIL levels. At 36.0%, average board representation is ahead of broad market indexes (**see market summary stats in Section 1 above and also here**). A strong 62.7% of the top holdings have female board representation above the MSCI World's 32.9%, while 42.4% of the holdings have representation of over 40%. Board gender parity for the group stands at 17.1%, driven by strength among the North American and European holdings.

CEO representation ticked down to roughly 14%. This is still nearly twice the S&P 500 level of 7.9% and well above levels for the Fortune 500 (10.4%), MSCI World (6.8%) and MSCI ACWI (6.5%). This demonstrates that these funds are following their mandates even as WIL growth remains choppy in the broader market. Female chair representation has climbed to 15.2% -- more than double the global average of 6%. For women at the executive or management committee level, the GLEF top holdings average 27.2%, with North America scoring 31.0%, slightly above the average published by the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (30.6%). European holdings averaged 31.9%. The level of female executives among the Asian holdings remains low at 7.9%.

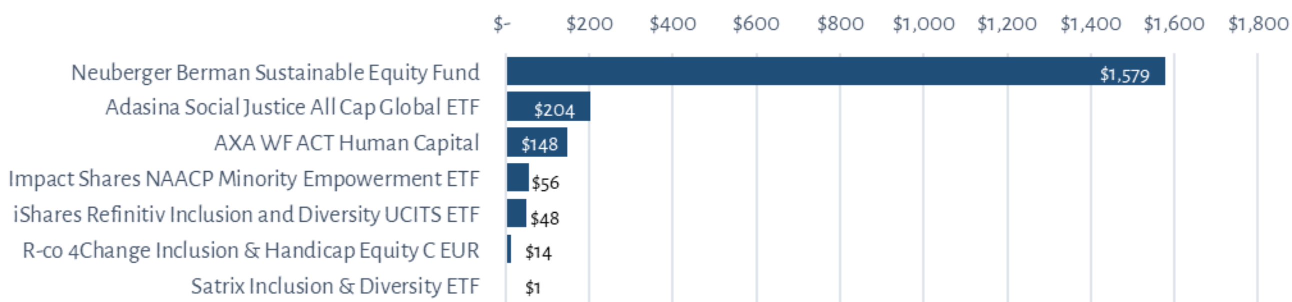
Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) Funds

A small but growing group of diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) funds employ investment criteria centered on companies with robust and publicly disclosed diversity policies. In our dataset, there are two global equity funds, two U.S. equity funds, two Europe equity funds, and one South Africa equity fund. See performance of these funds here.

In defining our coverage universe, DEI funds are centered on corporate policies around equality, diversity, and inclusion.

AUM in the DEI fund group was $2.0 billion as of December 31, 2024. AUM growth was flat for the quarter and 10.7% for the 12-month period for funds in our coverage throughout.

Figure 4.8: DEI Funds by AUM (in $ millions)



As of December 31, 2024
Sources: Fund factsheets

Contact us for a customized approach to an equality-focused investment portfolio.

The Gender Lens Investment Philosophy

Gender lens investing (GLI) is the direction of investment resources toward the achievement of gender equality. Broadly defined, GLI describes investment funds and portfolios in private and public capital markets segments. A breadth of studies spanning two decades, as summarized by Parallelle Finance here, has repeatedly shown connections between higher levels of women in leadership (WIL) and superior financial and operational performance. This includes superior share price returns, return on equity (ROE) and profitability, as well as lower incidences of fraud, better environmental decision-making, and improved risk management. These studies serve to demonstrate the rewards of gender diversity to companies and their investors – and clarify the costs to companies and economies of the persistent gaps in corporate gender diversity: lost profits, foregone EBITDA margins and ROE, lower revenue growth, dampened credit ratings, and lower earnings for women and their households.

Comprehensive workplace gender equality is a key factor in boosting WIL levels and realizing the many associated benefits. Research shows that voluntary or mandated public disclosure of unadjusted (median) gender pay gaps moves the needle on narrowing them. Paid caregiving leave has been shown to promote retention of female employees. In addition, anti-sexual harassment policies make a significant difference in retaining and promoting women. For sustained achievement of women in leadership, workplaces must hire, retain, and promote more women, as well as offer policies supportive of working families.

Appendix A: Global economic and financial gender gaps

2024 Global Gender Equality Indicators				Source*
WEF Global Gender Gap Report 2024 overall score (% gaps closed)	68.50%	2024		*WEF*
WEF years to full gender parity at current pace	134	2024		*WEF*
WEF Economic Participation and Opportunity Subindex score	60.5%	2024		*WEF*
Years required to close at current pace	152	2024		*WEF*
Years required to lift women and girls out of poverty at current pace	137	2024		*UN Women*
Women, Business, and the Law average country score	77.9%	2024		*WBG*
Countries with full rights for women to work/own assets	14	2024		*WBG*
Women in the Labor Force				**Source***
Labor Force Participation Rates (LFPRs):	**U.S. (12/24)**	**OECD (12/24)**	**Global (2023)**	
Adult women:	58.7%	67.1%	48.7%	*BLS; OECD; ILO*
Adult men:	*70.2%*	*80.8%*	*73.0%*	*BLS; OECD; ILO*
Adult Total:	*62.5%*	*73.9%*	*60.8%*	*BLS; OECD; ILO*
Adult women in prime working ages 25-54 (U.S. record high in 2024)	*appox 80%*		*68.0%*	*BLS; ILO*
with child(ren) age 5/under (U.S. unchanged in over a year)	*approx 70%*		*56.6% (2024)*	*BLS; ILO*
Adult men in prime age, not single, with children age 5/under			*94.5% (2024)*	*ILO*
Global jobs gap: Want job but don't have one, women / men (2024):			13.7% / 9.3%	*ILO*
Unpaid Labor (2023-4)				
% of countries that guarantee min. 14 weeks paid leave for mothers			65.0%	*WBG*
Child care costs, % of h/h earnings	8.9%-16%	9% (2022)		*DOL; OECD;*
U.S. largest metros where 2-child care costs > avg 2-bdrm rent	91 of 100			*LendingTree*
Full time working women vs. men time spent unpaid h/h labor	2x			*GEPI*
Gender Pay Gap (unadjusted)				**Source***
Global				
Gender pay gap (narrowed from 25% in 2015)	17%	2024		*Statista*
United States				
Gender pay gap	17%	2024		*PayScale*
Black women	21%	2024		*PayScale*
Hispanic women	22%	2024		*PayScale*
Asian women	5%	2024		*PayScale*
Gender pay gap for parents	25%	2024		*PayScale*
Gender pay gap at executive level	28%	2024		*PayScale*
Women earning under $17 per hour (vs. 19% of men)	28%	2024		*Oxfam America*
S&P 500 named exec officers gender pay gap	15%	2022		*Morningstar Sustainalytics*
Motherhood penalty in lifetime earnings	>$500,000	2023		*Bankrate*
Other Developed Economies				
U.K. pay gap full- and part-time workers	13.1%	2024		*UK Office of Nat. Stats*
FTSE 100 board members gender pay gap	69.0%	2024		*Business Matters*
Japan gender pay gap (100 largest companies)	21.0%	2024		*Bloomberg*
Australia gender pay gap	21.7%	2024		*WGEA*
OECD gender pay gap	11.3%	2023		*OECD*
Gender Wealth Gaps				**Source***
United States				
White women retirement income as % of men's	52.3%	2023		*American Assn of University Women*
Black women	49.5%	2023		*American Assn of University Women*
Hispanic women	33.5%	2023		*American Assn of University Women*
Single women without emergency savings	29.0%	2023		*Credit Karma*
Social security income gender gap (avg)	20.0%	2023		*American Assn of University Women*
Median retirement savings for women (vs $269,000 for men)	$185,000	2023		*Alliance for Lifetime Income*
Women invested in the stock market (representative survey)	71.0%	2023		*Fidelity*
Financial advisors, % women	23.60%	2023		*CFP Board*
Women who prefer adviser team to include a woman	54.00%	2023		*New York Life Investments*
Great Wealth Transfer: U.S. women expected to inherit through 2030	$30 trillion	2020		*McKinsey*
**Contact us for specific source information.*				

Appendix B: Women in Leadership (WIL and Workforce Metrics

Women in the population	Current	direction	Source*
Women as % of U.S. population:	50.5%		U.S. Census Bureau
Women as % of global population 2023:	49.7%		United Nations
U.S. WIL and workforce	**Current**	***direction***	**Source***
S&P 500 board seats Q324	34.0%	*Up from 28% in 2020 and 12% in 2000*	Spencer Stuart
S&P 500 boards with gender equality Q423	5.8%		Bloomberg
Fortune 500 board seats Q224	32.0%	*Up from 26.5% in 2020 and 11.7% in 2000*	Gemma Q
Fortune 500 board chairs Q224	10.0%		Gemma Q
Russell 1000 Index board seats Q223	32.0%	*Up from 23.8% in 2019*	50/50 WOB/Equilar
Russell 3000 Index board seats Q324	30.2%	*Up from 22.6% in 2020 and 15.1% in 2016*	50/50 WOB/Equilar
S&P CEOs 2024	52 (10.4%)		Women Business Collaborative
Fortune 500 CEOs 2024	58 (11.6%)	*Up from 15 (3%) in 2010 and 2 (0.4%) in 2000*	Fortune
Fortune 1000 CEOs Q22024	92 (9.2%)	*Up from 74 (7.4%) in 2022*	Women Business Collaborative
Russell 3000 CEOs Q22024	270 (9%)	*Up from 186 (6.2%) in 2022 and 96 (3.2%) in 2010*	Women Business Collaborative
S&P 500 executive suite	18.0%		Women Business Collaborative
Fortune 500 top executives Q323	26.6%		Gemma Q
Senior management 2024	33.8%		Bureau of Labor Statistics
Management 2024	41.8%		Bureau of Labor Statistics
Workforce 2024	47.1%		Bureau of Labor Statistics
Global WIL and workforce	**Current**	***direction***	**Source***
Global board seats 2023 (51 countries)	23%	*Up from 19.7% in 2021, 16.9% in 2018 and 15% in 2016*	Deloitte (next update 2026)
Global board chairs 2023	8%	*Up from 6.7% in 2021, 5.3% in 2018 and 3.8% in 2016*	Deloitte
Global CEOs 2023	6%	*Up from 5.0% in 2021, 4.4.% in 2018 and 3.9% in 2016*	Deloitte
Global CFOs 2023	18%	*Up from 15.7% in 2021 and 12.7% in 2018*	Deloitte
Fortune Global 500 CEOs 2023	29 (5.8%)		Fortune
FTSE 350 with 33% women on board 2024	94%	*Up from 63% in 2020*	FTSE Women Leaders
FTSE 350 with 40% women on board 2024	73%		FTSE Women Leaders
FTSE 350 executive+direct report 2024	35%	*Up from 31.2% in 2021*	FTSE Women Leaders
FTSE 350 CEOs 2024	9%		Pipeline Women Count
FTSE 350 CFOs 2024	22%		FTSE Women Leaders
FTSE 350 Executive Committee members 2024	32%		Pipeline Women Count
FTSE 350 women on boards 2024	43%		FTSE Women Leaders
FTSE 350 women board chairs 2024	17%		FTSE Women Leaders
FTSE 100 CEOs 2024	9%	*Up from 6% in 2019*	FTSE Women Leaders
FTSE 100 Executive Committee members 2024	33%		FTSE Women Leaders
MSCI ACWI board seats 2023	25.8%	*Up from 20.6% since 2020 and 17.3% since 2017*	MSCI (some updates pending)
MSCI ACWI board chairs 2023	9.1%	*Up from 4.8% in 2020 and 4.1% since 2018*	MSCI
MSCI ACWI CEOs 2023	6.5%	*Up from 4.8% in 2020 and 3.9% since 2017*	MSCI
MSCI ACWI CFOs 2023	18.8%	*Up from 15.1% in 2020 and 9.5% since 2017*	MSCI
MSCI World board seats 2023	32.5%	*Up from 30% since 2020 and 20.4% since 2017*	MSCI
MSCI World board chairs 2023	9.2%	*Up from 4.6% since 2020 and 3.7% since 2018*	MSCI
MSCI World CEOs 2023	6.8%	*Up from 4.9% in 2020 and 4.2% since 2017*	MSCI
MSCI World CFOs 2023	16.4%	*Up from 12.1% in 2020 and 9.4% since 2017*	MSCI
MSCI World executive committees 2024	24.0%		Mirova
MSCI World senior management 2022	25.0%	*Up from 21% since 2020*	Impax Ellevate
MSCI World middle management 2024	32.0%		Mirova
MSCI World global workforce 2024	38.0%		Mirova
MSCI EM board seats 2023	17.1%	*Up from 13.3% since 2020 and 10.2% since 2017*	MSCI
MSCI EM board chairs 2023	9.0%	*Up from 5.1% since 2020 and 4.8% since 2018*	MSCI
MSCI EM CEOs 2023	6.2%	*Up from 4.8% since 2020 and 3.3% since 2017*	MSCI
MSCI EM CFOs 2023	21.3%	*Up from 18.7% since 2020 and 9.8% since 2017*	MSCI
MSCI World Women's Leadership board seats Q32024 (wgt avg)	42.8%		MSCI
Equileap dataset board seats 2023	30%	*Up from 25% in 2021*	Equileap (2024 data pending)
Equileap board chairs 2023	9%		Equileap
Equileap CEOs 2023	7%		Equileap
Equileap CFOs 2023	15%		Equileap
Equileap dataset executive level 2023	22%	*Up from 17% in 2021*	Equileap
Equileap senior management 2023	27%	*Up from 24% in 2021*	Equileap
Equileap workforce 2023	38%		Equileap
**Contact us for specific source information.*			

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